Lesson 42 material: Word Order

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Unit 19 Word Orders

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/unit-19word-orders/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Unit 19 Word Orders

Learning Objectives

1. To learn the word orders in basic sentences, time and location expressions, frequency words, adjectives, and embedded questions
2. To understand and practice different word orders through multiple examples and a variety of writing situations

I. Pretest

(Picture: a computer with lines of codes on a desk)

a computer with lines of codes on a desk

In the following ten sentences about the MOOCS, some parts are bold-faced and may contain mistakes in word order. If the bold-faced part is correct, choose "correct". If not, choose the other answer. After you finish one sentence, you will get instant feedback on your answer before the next sentence. If you make mistakes, you can retry all the questions or see all the answers at the end of the pre-test.

EXERCISE

1. 1. **MOOC stands** for Massive Open Online Course.
a) correct b) Stands MOOC

2. 2. MOOCs cover **areas different** such as natural sciences, business, linguistics, computer science, engineering, and many more.
a) correct b) different areas

3. 3. Most **world-famous universities** offer MOOCs.
a) correct b) universities world-famous

4. 4. **Always MOOCs are online**.
a) correct b) MOOCs are always online.

5. 5. Students spend **every week about two to three hours**.
a) about two to three hours every week b) correct

6. 6. They can finish **some courses in four weeks**.
a) correct b) in four weeks some courses

7. 7. According to one MOOC course on insects, one type of **red small ants** is called fire ants.
a) correct b) small red ants

8. 8. Some people like to know how big are they.
a) correct b) how big they are

9. 9. They also want to know **where can they find fire ants**.
a) correct b) where they can find fire ants

10. 10. Fire ants **live usually** in Southeast and Southwest of the U.S.
a) correct b) usually live

II. Importance of Word Order

Word order refers to the arrangement of words in a sentence. While the word order in some sentences can be flexible, there are certain rules to show the proper sequence of words. If such rules are not followed, the sentences may sound very strange.

- Always MOOCs are online. **X**
- MOOCs are always online. √
- Students spend every week about two to three hours. **X**
- Students spend about two to three hours every week. √

III. Basic Word/Sentence Orders

You have studied basic sentence patterns in Unit 7 Sentence Essentials. For review, *open Unit 7 here*. Those patterns also show the basic word orders:

subject + verb + direct object

1. MOOC stands for Massive Open Online Course.
2. MOOCs cover different areas such as natural sciences, business, linguistics, computer science, engineering, and many more.
3. Many of them take three to ten weeks to complete.
4. Many world-class universities offer MOOCs.

subject + verb + indirect object + direct object

1. My friends gave my sister and me some information on MOOCs yesterday.

2. The information showed us the courses in computer science.

subject + linking verb + subject complement

1. MOOCs are open and free to everyone
2. Some of them are at very low cost, below $100 each.
3. MOOCs are self-paced[1].
4. They have grown more and more popular.

IV. Order of Time and Location Words

Time and location words can be placed in the beginning or end of a sentence. The general principle is to order them from a smaller unit to a larger one. If there are both time and location words in the same sentence, the location usually comes before time. Another option is to place one of them in the beginning and the other in the end of the sentence.

1. Next week, my friend and I are starting a new MOOC course in Spanish.
2. We are starting a new MOOC course in Spanish next week.
3. The last time it was offered was in January 2021. *(month before year)*
4. We are able to choose the course from the Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona in Spain or the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico. *(university before country)*
5. We are starting our Spanish MOOC course from the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico next week. *(place before time)*
6. Next week, we are starting our Spanish MOOC course from the Metropolitan Autonomous University in Mexico. *(time expression in the beginning and location expression in the end)*

V. Order of Frequency Words

Frequency words and expressions are common, but their positions in a sentence can be confusing. The following charts shows some general rules.

Frequency words	Beginning of Sentence	Middle of Sentence:	Before "do" verbs	After "be" verbs	Between helping verb and main verb	End of	Sentence
Always	X	√	X				
Usually	√	√	X				
Often	X	√	√				
Frequently	√	√	√				
Sometimes	√	√	√				
Occasionally	√	√	√				
Seldom	√ *	√	X				
Rarely	√ *	√	X				
Never	√ *	√	X				
Every day	√	X	√				
Every other week	√	X	√				
Once every three months	√	X	√				
Twice a year	√	X	√				

**A helping verb is required before the subject.*

Yellow areas: The 1-word frequency words can be placed in the middle of a sentence – before a "do" verb, after a "be" verb, or between a helping verb and a main verb.

For detailed explanations and examples of "do", "be", helping, and main verbs, please refer to Unit 9 Verb Basics in Academic Writing. Open Unit 9 here.

1. Students always like to take interesting online classes.
2. For working students, MOOCs are often more convenient than in-person classes.
3. Many students had never taken an online class before the Covid19 pandemic.

With gray checkmarks√ : Frequency adverbs like " frequently, sometimes, occasionally" can be placed in the beginning, in the middle, or at the end of a sentence.

1. Some working parents frequently take MOOCs.
2. Sometimes MOOCs charge a small fee for students who want to have a certificate upon completion.
3. Some of my friends take MOOCs occasionally.

Green areas: When "seldom, rarely, never" are used to begin a sentence, there should be a helping verb before the subject.

1. Seldom do full time students take extra courses outside of their college because they are already very busy.
2. Rarely are parents and their adult children studying in the same college, but the trend is growing.
3. Never will there be a time when MOOCs disappear, I hope.

Purple areas: Most frequency expressions with 2+ words are usually placed in the beginning or at the end of a sentence, not in the middle of a sentence.

1. Some MOOCs are offered several times a year.
2. Every week, students study for certain hours.
3. For example, CS50's Introduction to Artificial Intelligence with Python is offered free by Harvard University. It takes seven weeks to finish. Students will study ten to thirty hours a week. (*https://online-learning.harvard.edu/course/cs50s-introduction-artificial-intelligence-python?delta=0. Last accessed on October 3, 2021.)*

Exercise 1. The following sentences are about taking MOOCs. Some words are bold-faced. Mark "True" for the sentences with the correct word order and "False" for the sentences with the wrong word order. If you make a mistake, you can retry the sentence. The corrections for the wrong sentences are provided in **blue.**

(Picture: computer screens showing "MOOC")

computer screens showing "MOOC"

EXERCISE

1. 1. I took **a few years ago** several MOOC courses in sociology and psychology. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 2. They were offered **by universities in England and Australia.** (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 3. Always I chose the free classes. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 4. For each course, I **two times a week** studied in the evening for two hours. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. I usually read everything in the course, but I participated **seldom** in online discussions. There were too many posts from other students, and I simply gave up writing mine! (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 6. The quizzes and exams **often** consisted of multiple choice questions, so fortunately I did not need to write essays. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 7. I **never** have taken a science course because I am not good at science. (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 8. However, maybe I should try one **sometimes**. Who knows? I may come to like science. (True / False)

Exercise 2. Below are links to some MOOC courses offered through Coursera[2] by the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, Yale University, and University of Michigan. Open the links to see the course information. Would you be interested in any of them now or in the near future?

- Course #1: Writing and Editing: Structure and Organization

https://www.classcentral.com/course/writing-editing-structure-19554

- Course #2: Introduction to Classical Music

https://www.classcentral.com/course/introclassicalmusic-2987

- Course #3: Fundamentals[3] of Accounting

https://www.coursera.org/programs/coursera-for-illinois-gp2ja/browse?authProvider=illinois&productId=2zesAZFiEeaDSw63XnFBtQ&productType=course&query=accounting&showMiniModal=true

- Course #4: Cloud Computing[4] Concepts Part 1

https://www.coursera.org/programs/coursera-for-illinois-gp2ja/browse?authProvider=illinois&productId=op_vMOGiEeWr4g7T_DyXNw&productType=course&query=computer+science&showMiniModal=true

- Course #5: Essentials of Global Health

https://www.classcentral.com/course/essentials-global-health-7337

For more information, check MOOC.org.

(Links last accessed on July 20, 2021)

VI. Order of Adjectives

Adjectives describe nouns and are placed before nouns. Adjectives give more specific and interesting information such as shape, smell, taste, color, and other qualities. When using more than one adjective in succession[5], it is important to know which one comes first and which one comes next.

1. The baby is sleeping in a quiet, beautiful room. X
2. The baby is sleeping in a beautiful, quiet room. √
3. He is covered with a cotton, square blanket. X
4. He is covered with a square, cotton blanket. √

Adjectives usually follow the order below:

Determiner	Opinion	Size	Age	Shape	Color	Origin	Religion	Material	Purpose	Noun as Adjective						
a/an/the	a lot of	a few	each/every	many/some	my/your	one, two...	several	...	useful	difficult	friendly	happy	...	big	short	s

Exercise 3. Drop the given adjectives and nouns in the right order in each sentence about a baby and his room. You will get instant feedback on your choices. After each question, you may retry or see the answers.

EXERCISE

1. The baby has _____, _____ _____.

EXERCISE

2. There is a _____,_____ on the wall in the baby's room.

EXERCISE

3. Against the opposite wall, there is an _____,_____.

EXERCISE

4. Several _____,_____,_____are on the floor in the corner of the room.

EXERCISE

5. The baby's _____,_____ always likes to watch the baby and hum a lullaby as he sleeps.

VII. Order in Embedded Questions

Sometimes there is a question inside a sentence or inside another question. That is why it is called an "embedded[9] question". It is common to hear some people incorrectly say or ask:

- We would like to know where is the childcare center.
- Could you tell us which room should my child go to?

In such "embedded questions", the question part should not follow the usual question order. Instead, it should be:

question word + subject + verb

The correct way:

- We would like to know where the childcare center is.
- Could you tell us which room my child should go to?

Study more examples:

1. "What time is the childcare center open?" (direct question)
2. Please tell me what time the childcare center is open. (embedded question)
3. "Who is my child's teacher?" (direct question)
4. Do you know who my child's teacher is? (embedded question)
5. "How many children are there in one class?" (direct question)
6. The teacher has not told us how many children there are in one class. (embedded question)
7. "What time must we pick up our child?" (direct question)
8. I want to be certain what time we must pick up our child. (embedded question)

Exercise 4. Choose the correct word order in the following sentences with embedded questions about a day care center. You will receive instant feedback. You may retry the sentence or see the answer after you complete each question.

(Picture: a kindergarten classroom)

a kindergarten classroom

EXERCISE

1. 1. The parents are trying to find out _____.

a) What time the parents can meet the teacher b) what time can the parents meet the teacher

EXERCISE

1. 2. The parents want to know _____.

a) what volunteer work they can do there b) what volunteer work can they do there

EXERCISE

1. 3. The teacher is asking _____.

a) what time the parents are available to help b) what time are the parents available to help

EXERCISE

1. One of the teachers is trying to find out _____.

a) why is little Mia absent. b) why little Mia is absent.

EXERCISE

1. 5. The kids are wondering _____.

a) when is their snack time b) when their snack time is

VIII. Unit Review Practice

Exercise 5. Choose the correct word order for the following sentences about a pet dog. In the right order, drag the words or phrases to the boxes. You will receive instant feedback. After each question, you may retry or see the answers.

Example:

friend, Teddy, dog, good, my, pet, is

My pet dog Teddy is my good friend.

EXERCISE

1. He is a _____, _____ _____ _____.

EXERCISE

2. Teddy _____ wags his _____,_____ tail when he sees me.

EXERCISE

3. He may be asking me _____ _____ _____ _____.

EXERCISE

4. He _____ _____ _____.

EXERCISE

I _____ _____ him _____.

EXERCISE

_____ I tell Teddy _____ _____ _____.

EXERCISE

I hope he _____ _____ _____ _____ _____.

Exercise 6. The following paragraph about two puppies in love is adapted from a previous unit. Arrange the given words in the right order and type them in the boxes. Type only one word in each box. You will get instant feedback on your answers. When you complete the entire exercise, you may retry or see all the answers.

The first sentence is an example:

(Picture: a dog jumping from ocean)

a dog jumping from ocean

The story happened on a ***small Japanese***

(Japanese, small) island Aka in the 1980s.

EXERCISE

Puppies in Love A long time ago, a dog named Shiro became famous and received a nickname “Puppy in Love”. The story happened on a small Japanese (Japanese, small) island Aka in the 1980s. Shiro belonged to Mr. and Mrs. Nakamura. He would disappear every few days. It _____ _____ (usually, happened) in the morning, but _____ _____ (always, he) came back at night. He _____ _____ (always, was) wet when he returned. Mr. and Mrs. Nakamura were surprised and curious. They wanted to find out where _____ _____ (went, Shiro). One day, Mr. Nakamura followed Shiro to the beach and saw him run into the cold water. When Shiro started to swim, Mr. Nakamura jumped onto his _____ _____ (little, fishing) boat and followed him. Three hours later, Shiro got onto an island called Zamami and walked to a _____ _____ (wooden, beautiful) house. He started to play with a _____ _____ (lovely, small) puppy there. The two puppies were in love! It turned out that the Makamuras had been living in Zamami before they moved. The two puppies had become good friends. After the Nakamuras moved, Shiro _____ _____ (visited, frequently) his girlfriend puppy. In the evening, he swam back home to Aka. When Shiro’s story became public, many people came to Aka and Zamami to see them. They wondered how long _____ _____ (Shiro, swam). The ocean between the two islands was actually more than two miles long, and people were amazed to see the puppies in love!

Exercise 7. Choose one of the following topics to write a paragraph. Include some adjectives and frequency words.

1. Whom do you love the most? Describe him or her.
2. What is the best gift you have received? Describe it.
3. Which is your favorite room in your house or apartment? Describe it.

4. What has been the most exciting scene you have seen? (for example, a parade[10], a party, a ceremony, etc.) Describe it.

NSNT Practice

(Picture: a pen writing in a notebook)

a pen writing in a notebook

Go to **The NSNT Free Writing Approach and Additional Weekly Prompts for Writing** in Appendix A. *(Open Appendix A here.)* Choose two topics that you have not written about. You may start with the NSNT approach. Then revise and edit your paragraphs. Pay attention to the word order. You are encouraged to share your writing with your partner and help each other improve.

EXERCISE

Writing task: You may write in your notebook or in the box below. (Warning: Once you leave this page, you will lose what you have written in the box.) .

Vocabulary Review

(Picture: a page in a dictionary)

a page in a dictionary

The words here have appeared in this unit. The best way to learn them is to guess the meaning of each word from the context. Then hover your computer mouse over the number beside each word to check its meaning and part of speech. These words are also listed in the footnote area at the end of each unit.

Here, you can use the flashcards below to review these words.

EXERCISE

- **self-paced**: adjective, learning at one's own speed
- **Coursera**: noun, an online course provider that works with many universities https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Coursera
- **fundamentals**: noun, basics
- **cloud computing**: the delivery of computer services such as servers and storage https://azure.microsoft.com/en-us/overview/what-is-cloud-computing/
- **in succession**: prepositional phrase, one after another
- **circular**: adjective, round, like a circle
- **hiking boots**: noun phrase, boots that people wear when they are hiking
- **paring knife**: noun phrase, a small knife for cutting, chopping, slicing, and other kitchen tasks
- **embedded**: adjective, located in the middle of something
- **parade**: noun, a large public procession to celebrate an important event, usually with music

Summary

1. Word order means the sequence of words in a sentence.
2. The basic word/sentence orders are:
   - Subject + verb + direct object
   - Subject + verb + indirect object + direct object
   - Subject + link verb + subject complement
3. When there are time words and location words,
   - They can be placed in the beginning or end of a sentence.
   - Arrange the time or location from a smaller unit to a larger unit.
   - Location words usually come before time words.
3. Frequency adverbs and expressions may be placed:
   - in the beginning of a sentence
   - in the middle (before an action verb, after a “be” verb, or between a helping verb and a main verb)
   - at the end of a sentence
4. With more than one adjective in succession, arrange them in proper order: determiner, opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, religion, material, purpose, noun as adjective.
5. An embedded question needs to follow the order: question word + subject + verb.

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1. self-paced: adjective, learning at one's own speed ↵

2. Coursera: noun, an online course provider that works with many universities. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Coursera ↲
3. fundamentals: noun, basics ↲
4. cloud computering: the delivery of computer services such as servers and storage https://azure.microsoft.com/en-us/overview/what-is-cloud-computing/ ↲
5. in succession: prepositional phrase, one after another ↲
6. circular: adjective, round, like a circle ↲
7. hiking boots: noun phrase, boots that people wear when they are hiking ↲
8. paring knife: noun phrase, a small knife for kitchen tasks like cutting, chopping, and slicing ↲
9. embedded: adjective, located in the middle of something ↲
10. parade: noun, a large public procession to celebrate an important event, usually with music ↲

Links on the original page

- Web page (online-learning.harvard.edu): https://online-learning.harvard.edu/course/cs50s-introduction-artificial-intelligence-python?delta=0
- Web page (classcentral.com): https://www.classcentral.com/course/writing-editing-structure-19554
- Web page (classcentral.com): https://www.classcentral.com/course/introclassicalmusic-2987
- Web page (coursera.org): https://www.coursera.org/programs/coursera-for-illinois-gp2ja/browse?authProvider=illinois&productId=2zesAZFiEeaDSw63XnFBtQ&productType=course&query=accounting&showMiniModal=true
- Web page (coursera.org): https://www.coursera.org/programs/coursera-for-illinois-gp2ja/browse?authProvider=illinois&productId=op_vMOGiEeWr4g7T_DyXNw&productType=course&query=computer+science&showMiniModal=true
- Web page (classcentral.com): https://www.classcentral.com/course/essentials-global-health-7337